

Vital Stats

GoToMyPc

Price: \$19.95 per month

Web site: www.gotomypc.com

Download size: 1.35 MB for the server, 200 KB for the viewer

Platforms: Windows 9x/NT/2000

Virtual Network Computing

Price: Free

Web site:

www.uk.research.att.com/vnc/download.html

Download size: 978 Kb

Platforms: Windows 9x/NT/2000, Linux, Unix, Sun Solaris

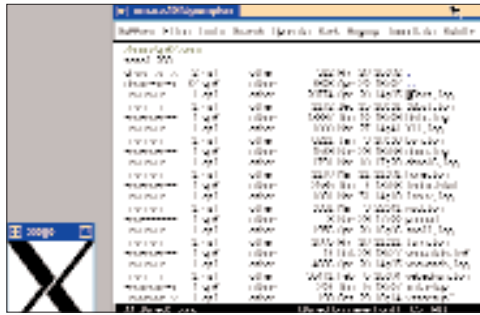
Accessing VNC using a Java-enabled browser

As an alternative to using the VNCviewer, you can also access the remote PC from any stand-alone Web browser that supports Java, like Internet Explorer. All that's needed is the machine name/IP address and the port (by default, this is set at 5800).

GoToMyPc

Expertcity's GoToMyPc allows you to control your PC from a remote location anywhere in the world, as long as you have an Internet connection and a Web browser. What sets GoToMyPc apart from other PC-controlling software is that it is a service instead of a specific software.

The best part of this Web-based service is that, unlike with most other services, you do not need a permanent IP address for the computer you wish to have control over. Simply register with the service and download a very small client program that rests in your system tray. Since a static IP address is not required to use this service, it is ideal for people who need to access their PC but don't know the technical properties of the network to which it is connected.



GoToMyPc with the MacOS desktop

Expertcity had originally started GoToMyPc to help out its technical support team, so that it could remotely help customers with their problems, without having to go on-site. But then, realising its potential, it made GoToMyPc a public service for anyone who wanted to connect to his or her PC from anywhere. Until May this year, Expertcity was offering the free beta version of GoToMyPc. But now the company has decided to charge a monthly fee of \$19.95 for a single user.

Set it up now

Step 1: Log on to gotomypc.com. Register to set up your account. You will need to give your credit card information after which the GoToMyPc software will be downloaded and will assign the remote PC an access code, user name and password, which is chosen by you.

Step 2: From the local machine, log on to gotomypc.com. Hit the connect button next to the nickname of the remote machine. A tiny 200-KB plugin will be downloaded automatically. This plugin lets you connect via your Web browser to the remote machine on which the GoToMyPc software has been installed.

The remote machine will respond to the local machine's monitor, keyboard and mouse. 

Should I go in for GoToMyPc?

This, of course, depends on the kind of use you would have for a service like this and whether you are willing to pay for it. There are lots of useful things that GoToMyPc allows you to do. The draw mode lets you draw anything on the remote machine's desktop with the mouse. The in-built chat applet lets users talk. These could be immensely useful to technicians in high-lighting areas of the screen and indicating things to the customer without being physically present.

A unique feature is the support for two-way file transfers. GoToMyPc does not use the conventional method of transferring captured video from the remote machine to the local machine. Actually, it uses a compression algorithm that efficiently transfers data.

One of the biggest disadvantages of GoToMyPc is that it is dependent on the speed of your Net connection. Even at 56 Kbps, there can be up to a 30-40 second lag between the two machines. Also, it only supports the Windows platform, though plans are underway to release a cross-platform version.

Another consideration is security. Even though it provides 128-bit encryption, it is not as secure as software such as Symantec's pcAnywhere. So companies that have highly sensitive data might not want to go in for this service.

On the other hand, it is a boon for people who have round-the-clock access to the Net at their workplace and need to access their machines regularly from home or while they're on the move.

